FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The descriptor 'Gen Z' does not usually evoke images of political insurrection. It refers to a generation born in the decade after the mid-1990s, stereotyped as digital natives raised on a steady diet of YouTube, Instagram reels and the like. Nepal was no exception, it seems. Its youth was so addicted to these platforms that a move to ban them appeared to trigger an uprising that toppled a government. That was the shorthand explanation for the sudden chaos and violence that gripped the Himalayan republic. But the scale of the destruction revealed far deeper and more serious reasons for the anger of the youth. They attacked the symbols of state power with unbridled fury. Parliament was vandalised and set on fire, as was the President's office, the Supreme Court, party headquarters, the houses of the President, the prime minister and politicians of all stripes. What was astonishing was the speed with which the insurrectionary scenes boiled over to a chaotic crescendo. A former PM and his foreign minister-wife were beaten up, the wife of another ex-PM died of burn injuries sustained during arson, the finance minister was chased in the streets, and an MP was stripped. They signalled a generation's searing anger boiling over.

To assume that a social media ban alone unleashed such violence is simplistic. Prima facie, that would constitute an extravagant live demo of the power of social media and how it can influence behaviour. And indeed, Nepal has a robust online ecosystem, with one of South Asia's highest user rates for popular platforms. Yet, premier K.P. Sharma Oli could not have anticipated what a shutdown would provoke. Given the scale of subversive energies on full display, it's clear that the social media ban was merely the final spark. Beneath it all lay years of frustration with corruption, nepotism and ostentation of a ruling elite that promised good governance but delivered little. Thus, as its representatives voiced it, the 'Gen Z protests' were an act of ethical cleansing of governance.

▲ June 18, 2001

Underlying this pent-up desire for change is the usual spectre of joblessness. In the 2021 census, those under 30 accounted for nearly 56 per cent of the country's population, with 42.5 per cent in the productive age range of 16-40. Nepal's overall unemployment rate stood at 10.8 per cent in 2024. But, significantly, among those in the Gen Z age group of 15-24, the rate had reached 20.8 per cent, nearly double the national rate. That's because, with the worst road infrastructure in Asia and a polity cursed by corruption and instability, Nepal has historically punched below its potential on foreign investment. At a mere 0.2 per cent of its GDP, it ranks the lowest in South Asia on FDI. Outside of farming and foreign aid, remittances form the cornerstone of the domestic economy. The lack of local job opportunities led to an estimated 4.5 million of Nepal's 29.6 million population migrating to India, the Gulf countries, the Far East, and similar destinations for employment. Remittance inflows are nearly $14 billion, accounting for 33 per cent of the GDP. Over three quarters of all households depend on them; on average, they form a third of the income of such households. Yet this cannot absorb the hopes of a restless generation.

This turbulence exposed the fragility of Nepal's democracy. Born as a full parliamentary republic only in 2008, after a harrowing and heroic struggle against monarchy, it has failed to live up to the economic aspirations of its people. The same cast of faces hold on to power in a dreary game of musical chairs. The roll-call has included 13 prime ministers since 2008. Oli and Pushpa Kumar Dahal 'Prachanda' figure four times each, and Sher Bahadur Deuba five times in all, including the pre-2008 phase of partial monarchy. Nepal's ethnic fault lines compound the malaise. Elite castes (31 per cent) monopolise power, and various indigenous groups, as well as the Madhesis, languish in degrees of alienation. The failure to deliver jobs and dignity has left politics stuck in a low trough incapable of responding to an impatient youth bulge.

Today, the challenge is not just to restore law and order but also to rescue the polity itself. The army, commendably aloof from power, has enforced calm. But the search for an interim government is fraught, and the very constitution is in peril. The ransacking of Parliament exposed an anti-democratic undercurrent, with some tracing it to entrenched royalist lobbies. Oli, now a fugitive, has blamed India, a standard scapegoat in Nepalese politics. Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Deputy Editor Pradip R. Sagar capture a critical moment in Nepal's political history for our cover story this week and look at the way forward for this troubled nation. Also, what it means for India. Though New Delhi has erred in the past, notably with the 2015 trade blockade, it can hardly wish for anything other than stability across its open border.

For India, the lesson is sobering. A neighbour's wasted demographic dividend has exploded into flames on Kathmandu's streets. We've seen similar eruptions in Bangladesh in 2024 and Sri Lanka in 2022. The same risk hovers over any polity unable to provide jobs, dignity and hope to its youth. In today's interconnected world, the failure to deliver can transform a generation into revolutionaries. Also, social media is now regarded as a fundamental right by the new generation. That is the enduring message of Nepal's Gen Z revolt.

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